



Productside

AI-AUGMENTED PRODUCT DISCOVERY

Build the Right Thing Before Building It Right.

AI made building dramatically cheaper and faster. It did not make knowing what to build any easier.

Five ways to build it right and still miss

- | | | |
|----|--------------------------------|--|
| 01 | Relay.app | Differentiation must keep being earned. |
| 02 | Humane AI Pin | Novelty does not equal customer value. |
| 03 | Google Gemini image generation | Optimizing one thing can break another. |
| 04 | Air Canada chatbot | Automation does not outsource accountability. |
| 05 | Zillow Offers | Model performance does not guarantee business viability. |

THE STARTING REQUEST

Build an AI predictive-maintenance dashboard.

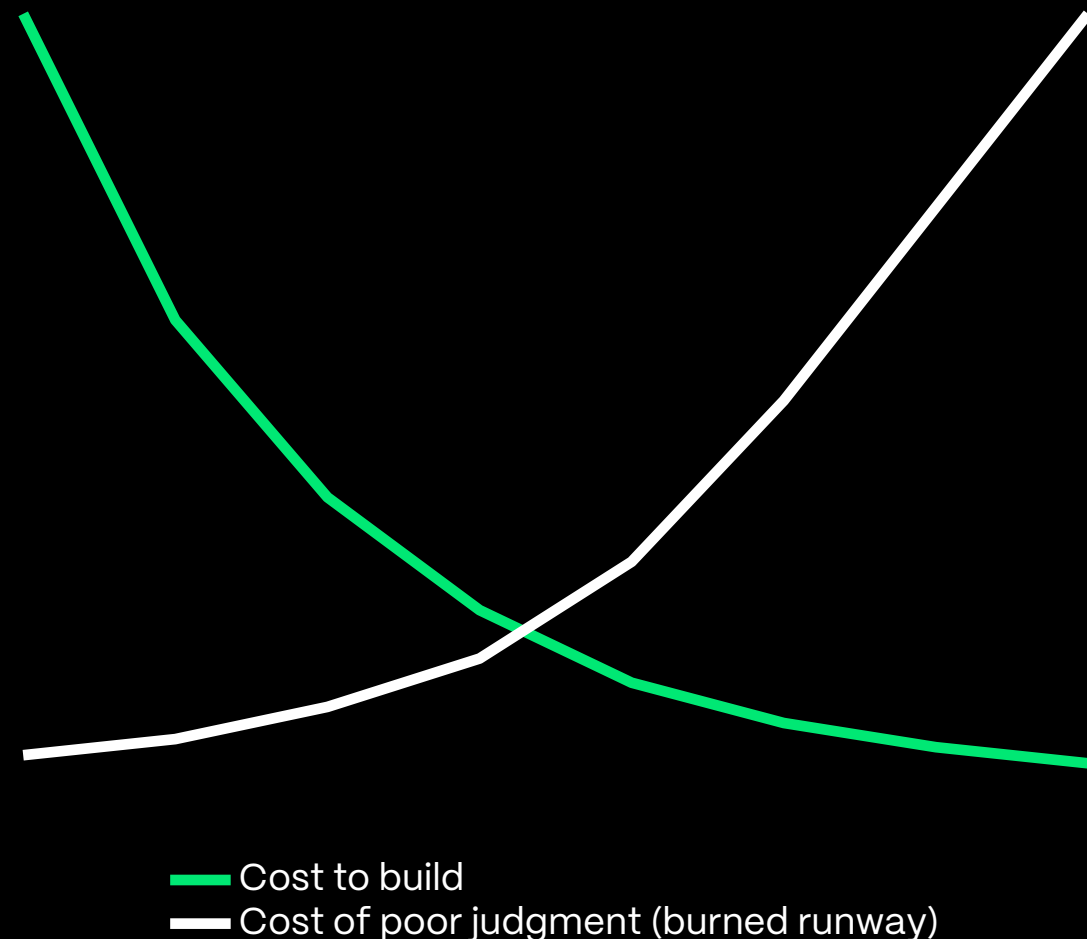
UNKNOWN

What would you need to know before funding that?

This manufacturing scenario is SYNTHETIC. No customers were interviewed. These aren't customers. They're hypothesis-generating machines.

The AI cost paradox

Teams can now build the wrong thing faster, and polish a weak assumption into a shipped feature. Progress means uncertainty reduced, not activity increased.



Illustrative shape only. Not measured data.

What problem are we
solving, and for
whom?

01

Market Intel

What is the landscape, and how much of what we know is evidence?

ARTIFACT: MARKET INTELLIGENCE BRIEF

RULE A market sweep is not a segment.

HANDOFF CARD

TARGET

BELIEF

EVIDENCE

INFERRED

OUTCOME

QUESTION

THE EVIDENCE LEGEND

ACTUAL DATA

INFERRED

ESTIMATE

UNKNOWN

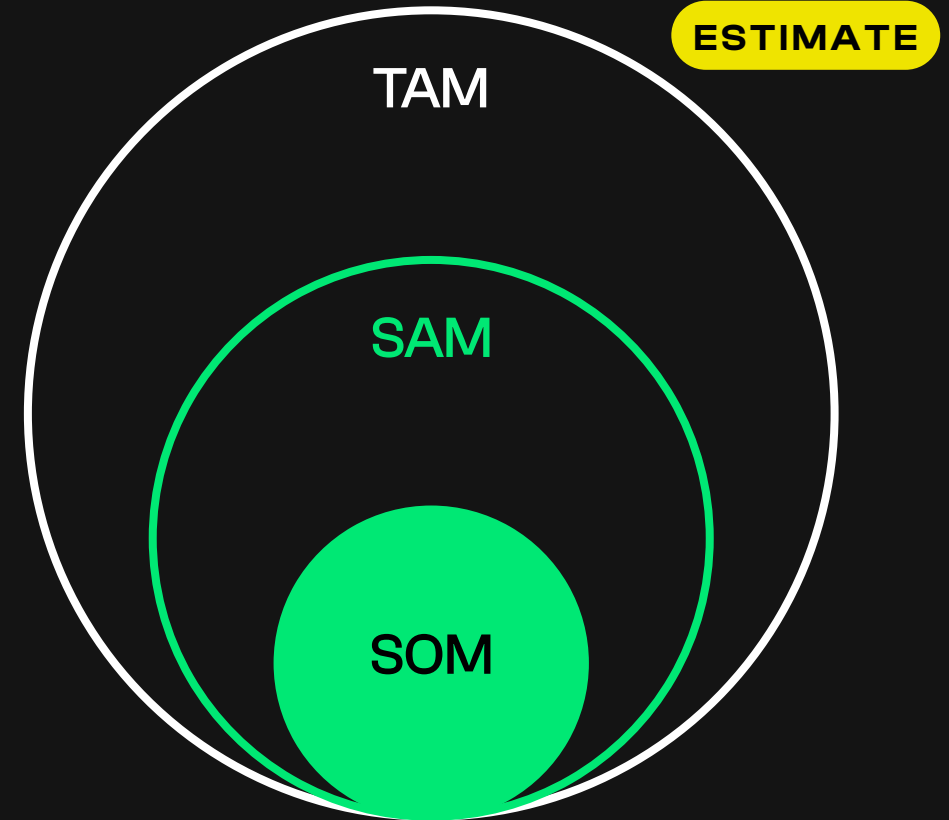
02

Segment

Which bounded context are we deliberately choosing to learn about?

ARTIFACT: SEGMENT SELECTION BRIEF

RULE Sizing is an estimate until it is sourced.
Choosing a segment is not proof it is attractive.



TAM from population

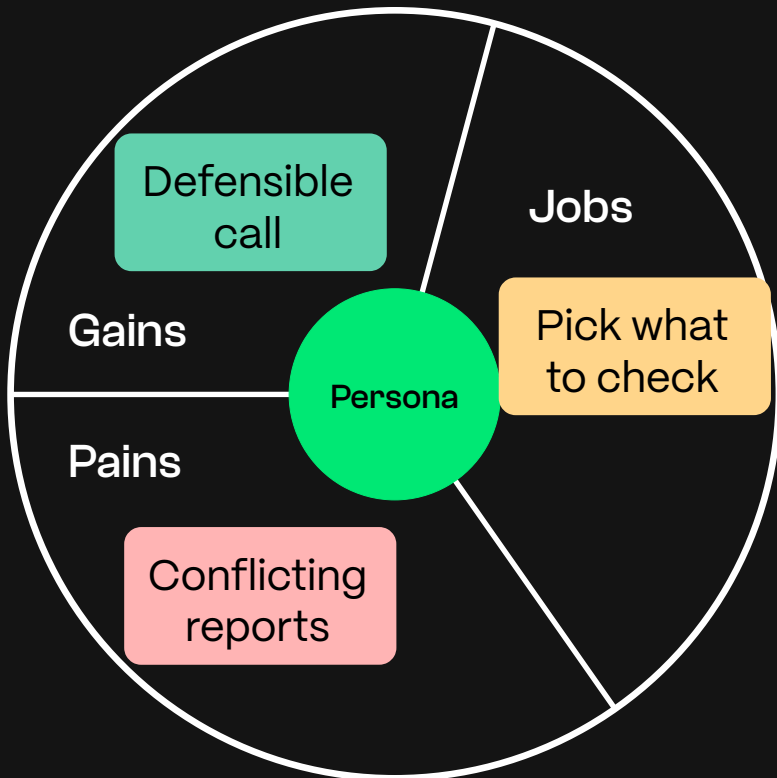
SAM from trade and industry

SOM from competition and reach

03 Persona

Who is this person, in what situation, trying to make what progress?

1 List



2 Pick the top

Top job

Pick what to check next

Top gain

Explain it fast

Top pain

Reports disagree

3 Frame the problem

I am a maintenance manager.

Trying to pick what to check next.

But the reports disagree.

Because source and timing are hidden.

Makes me feel unsure.

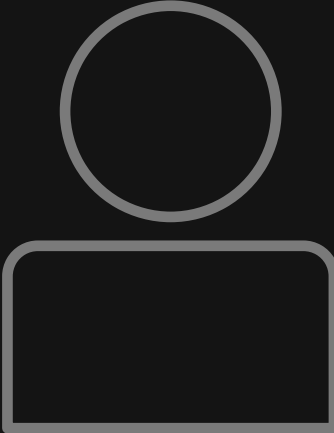
SYNTHETIC. ALL ESTIMATE.

ARTIFACT: SITUATIONAL PERSONA

RULE A hypothesis, not a customer we interviewed.

03 Proto-Persona

Who is this person, in what situation, trying to make what progress?

NAME Maintenance manager	BIO Mid-sized plant Reports conflict Checks logs, asks a tech	QUOTES UNKNOWN No interviews, no quotes
PORTRAIT  A role, not a person	OUTCOMES Clearer decisions A choice I can explain	PAINS Reports disagree Permission? UNKNOWN

ARTIFACT: SITUATIONAL PERSONA

RULE A hypothesis, not a customer we interviewed.

Where do we play,
where do we win?

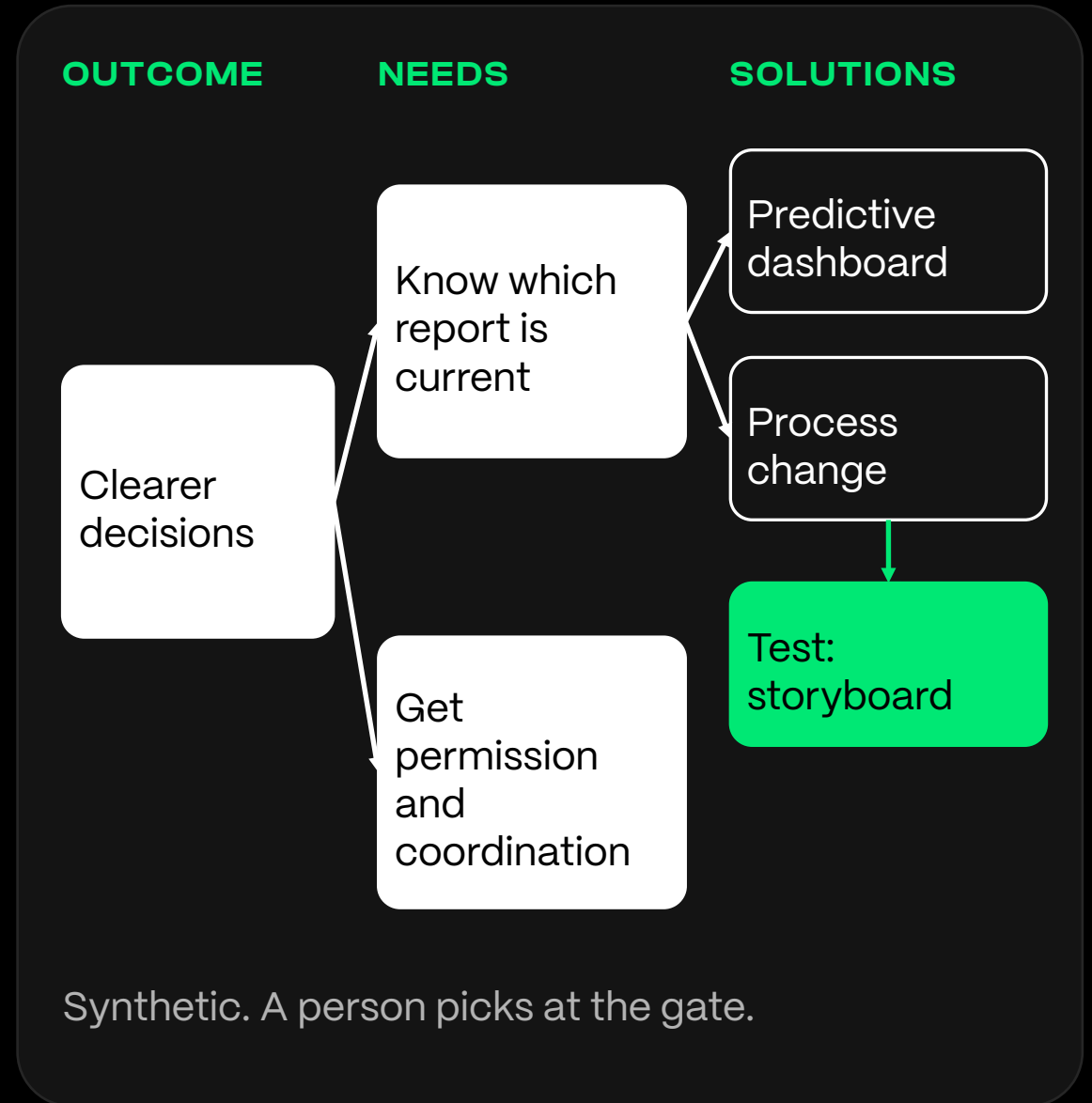
04

Opportunity Solution Tree

Which needs are worth pursuing, and which solutions and cheap experiments hang off them?

ARTIFACT: OPPORTUNITY SOLUTION TREE

RULE A dashboard is a solution candidate, not a need.



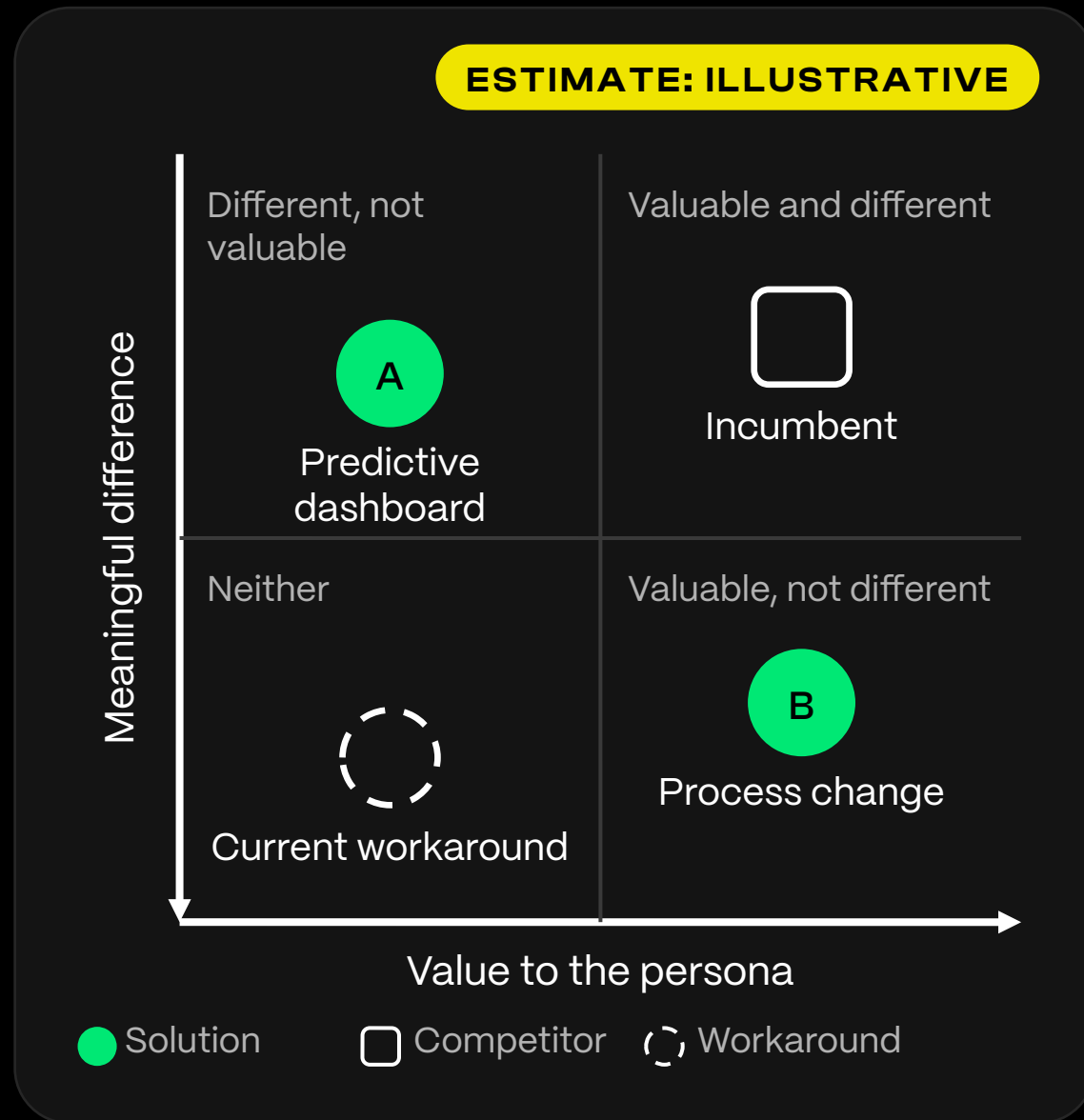
05

Value Prop vs. Differentiation 2x2

Where does each solution from the tree sit? Does the value matter, and is the difference meaningful?

ARTIFACT: 2X2

RULE Different is not the same as valuable. AI novelty is evidence of neither.



06 Positioning Statement

Why is this for this person, and why would they choose it over today's workaround?

For	maintenance managers
Who	must pick what to check next
The	shared report view
Is a	decision aid
That	shows source and timing
Unlike	log review and chats
Our product gives	a reason others can inspect

ARTIFACT: POSITIONING STATEMENT

RULE A proposed difference is not a reason to believe.

What must be true,
how do we learn?

07 Solution Hypothesis

What do we believe will change, and what would make us revise or stop?

IF / THEN

NOT RUN

If we show source and timing, **for** maintenance managers, **then we will** help them pick and explain the next check.

2 TINY ACTS OF DISCOVERY

1. Compare with and without source
2. Walk one real past decision

1 QUANT + 1 QUAL METRIC

1. Time to explain the choice
2. Easier to defend, they say

REVISE OR STOP IF

Permission, not data, decides the choice.

ARTIFACT: SOLUTION HYPOTHESIS

RULE Write the rule before the result exists.

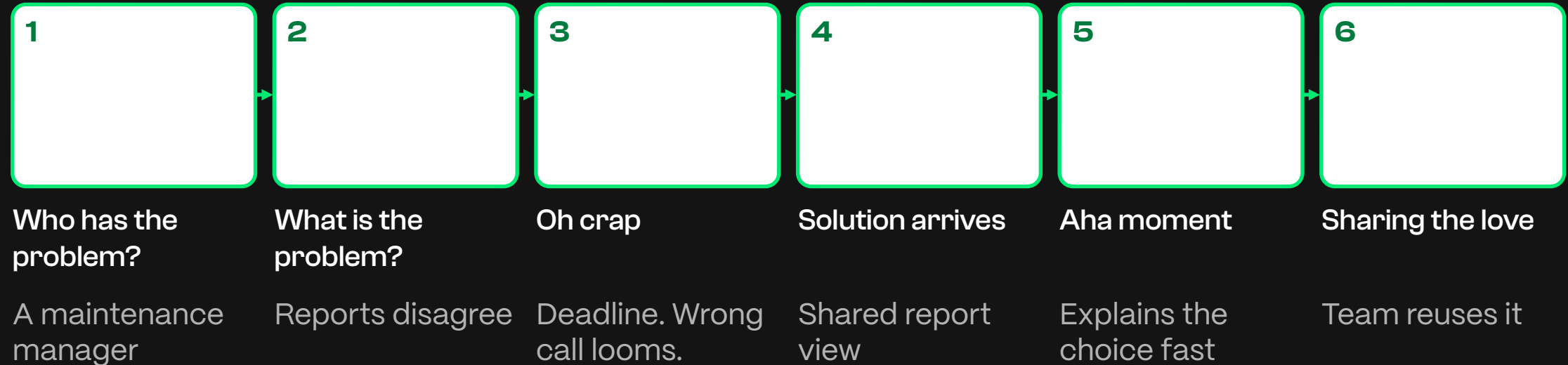
08 Storyboard

What does the story look like, from who has the problem to who else gets the win?

SOLUTION SUMMARY

NOT RENDERED | SYNTHETIC

If we show source and timing, managers choose with less doubt.



ARTIFACT: STORYBOARD

RULE Aim for authenticity, simplicity and emotion.

09 Minimum Viable Narrative

What is the smallest story worth testing?

PROTOTYPE HYPOTHESIS

Source and timing visible, so managers choose and explain faster.

TARGET AUDIENCE

A maintenance manager at a mid-sized plant

SETUP

Two reports disagree

ENCOUNTER

A shared report view

LOOP: 3 TO 6 EXCHANGES

ACTION

Asks what is behind it

RESPONSE

Shows source, time

RESOLUTION

Explains it and acts

BUILDER PROMPT

Descriptive, not prescriptive.

NOT BUILT

ARTIFACT: MINIMUM VIABLE NARRATIVE

RULE The smallest story worth testing.

10

Prototyping

What is the smallest, cheapest test we can run to learn the most brutal truth?

ARTIFACT: PROTOTYPE EXPERIMENT BRIEF

RULE The tiniest act that gives enough signal to pivot, punt or pursue.

~~Build an AI predictive-maintenance dashboard.~~

TINIEST ACT THAT TELLS THE TRUTH

The fidelity ladder

Lo-fi, if it tells the truth.

What can we learn at this fidelity that we could not learn more cheaply?

The most expensive way to test your idea is to build **production quality software.**

Jeff Patton

Conversation
Lowest cost

Storyboard /
wireframe
Low cost

Interaction
Medium cost

Code / build
Highest cost

Choose the lightest useful abstraction

PROMPT

Explore

Paste it into any chat.

SKILL

Codify

A bounded,
repeatable play.

AGENT

Delegate

An operator pursuing
an outcome.

PLUGIN

Distribute

The kit.

Today Dean operates the chain. No autonomous discovery operator exists. Ten artifacts do not prove demand.

Learn faster.
Decide better.
Then build.

Pick one motion. Bring your own context. Try it tomorrow.



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